

Silver Branch Plant Survey 3
Solicitation Number: 12443926Q0069

Description

This is a combined synopsis/solicitation for commercial items prepared in accordance with the format in FAR Part 12. This announcement constitutes only the solicitation. Quotations are being requested and a separate written solicitation will not be issued.

Solicitation number 12443926Q0069 is issued as a Request for Quotation (RFQ) for Silver Branch Plant Survey Contract 3. The purpose of the contract is to survey specified areas of the Ottawa National Forest for the presence of Regional Forester's Sensitive plants, State of Michigan listed plants, other plants of potential viability concern, priority non-native invasive plants, and plants of cultural significance.

This acquisition is set-aside for small business concerns. The applicable North American Industry Classification Standard Code is 541620 The small business size standard is \$19 M. This acquisition is a Total Small Business Set-Aside. All responsible sources may submit a quotation which will be considered by the agency.

Statement of Requirement

The purpose of the contract is to survey specified areas of the Ottawa National Forest for the presence of Regional Forester's Sensitive plants, State of Michigan listed plants, other plants of potential viability concern, priority non-native invasive plants, and plants of cultural significance See attached Statement of Work, Attachment B for a complete list of requirements.

Schedule of Items

Item	Compartments	Number of Stands	Total Acres	Bid
1	D4 C 9, 57, 83-86, 88-90, 93, 116-122, 154; D5 C 115-119.	97	2,993.4	\$
2	D4 C 124-126, 147-151, 157-160, 162, 184-187, 190, 191.	92	1930.9	\$
3	D3 C 21, 22, 26, 29-34, 41-44, 46, 52, 53, 63, 64, 66-69, 71-73, 86-88, 90, 91, 95.	161	3,067.4	\$
	TOTAL	350	7,991.7	\$

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Technical Data

Technical data and supporting documentation associated with this solicitation are available through the following sources:

1. Solicitation Attachments

The following documents are included as attachments to this solicitation and can be accessed via the “Attachments/Links” section of the posting.

- Attachment A – Schedule of Items Silver Branch Survey
- Attachment B – Statement of Work Silver Branch Survey
- Attachment C – Maps Silver Branch Survey
- Attachment D - Silver Branch Survey Bundle Forms
- Attachment E – Michigan Special Plant Form
- Attachment F – Service Contract Act WD # 1981-0136 Rev 74 04/29/2026
- Attachment G - Service Contract Act WD # 2015-4871 REV 32 04/29/2026
- Attachment H – Experience Questionnaire

Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR) and United States Department of Agriculture Acquisition Regulation (AGAR) Clauses and Provisions

The clauses and provisions contained herein are applicable to any order awarded as a result of this solicitation. The terms and conditions set forth herein supersede all other terms and conditions. Acceptance of the order in accordance with (IAW) FAR 12.201-1(b)(2) constitutes acceptance of all terms and conditions contained herein.

As part of the Revolutionary FAR Overhaul (RFO), system updates may lag policy updates. The System for Award Management (SAM) may continue to require entities to complete representations based on provisions that are not included in this solicitation. Contracting officers will rely on representations from offers based on provisions in the solicitation. Entities are not required to, nor are they able to, update their entity registration to remove these representations in SAM.

52.252-2 Clauses Incorporated by Reference

Feb 1998

This solicitation incorporates one or more clauses by reference, with the same force and effect as if they were given in full text. Upon request, the Contracting Officer will make their full text available. Also the full text of the clause may be accessed electronically at Internet address <https://www.acquisition.gov/far-overhaul/far-part-deviation-guide/far-overhaul-part-52>

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|-----------|--|
| 52.212-4 | Terms and Conditions—Commercial Products and Commercial Services (Nov 2025)
☐ Alternate I (Nov 2025) of 52.212-4 |
| 52.203-17 | Contractor Employee Whistleblower Rights (Nov 2023) |
| 52.203-19 | Prohibition on Requiring Certain Internal Confidentiality Agreements or Statements (Jan 2017) |
| 52.222-50 | Combating Trafficking in Persons (Nov 2025)
☐ Alternate I (Nov 2025) of 52.222-50 |
| 52.226-8 | Encouraging Contractor Policies to Ban Text Messaging While Driving (May 2024) |
| 52.232-39 | Unenforceability of Unauthorized Obligations (Jun 2013) |

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- 52.232-40 Providing Accelerated Payments to Small Business Subcontractors (Mar 2023)
- 52.233-3 Protest After Award (Sep 2025)
- 52.233-4 Applicable Law for Breach of Contract Claim (Sep 2025)
- 52.240-91 Security Prohibitions and Exclusions (Nov 2025)
 - ☐ Alternate I (Nov 2025) of 52.240-91
- 52.244-6 Subcontracts for Commercial Products and Commercial Services (Nov 2025)

The following clauses are applicable if checked:

- ☒ 52.204-13 System for Award Management—Maintenance (Nov 2025)
- ☒ 52.209-10 Prohibition on Contracting with Inverted Domestic Corporations (Sep 2025)
- ☒ 52.219-6 Notice of Total Small Business Aside (Nov 2025)
 - ☐ Alternate I (Mar 2020).
- ☒ 52.222-3 Convict Labor (June 2003)
- ☒ 52.222-36 Equal Opportunity for Workers with Disabilities (Nov 2025)
 - ☐ Alternate I (Jul 2014) of 52.222-36
- ☒ 52.222-41 Service Contract Labor Standards (Aug 2018)
- ☒ 52.222-42 Statement of Equivalent Rates for Federal Hires (May 2014)

This Statement is for Information Only:
 It is not a Wage Determination

Employee Class	Monetary Wage -- Fringe Benefits
Farming, Fishing, and Forestry Occupations (45-0000)	\$20.39

- ☒ 52.222-62 Paid Sick Leave Under Executive Order 13706 (Jan 2022)
- ☒ 52.222-90 Addressing DEI Discrimination by Federal Contractors (Apr 2026)
- ☒ 52.223-2 Reporting of Biobased Products Under Service and Construction Contracts (Nov 2025)
- ☒ 52.223-23 Sustainable Products and Services (Nov 2025)
- ☒ 52.232-33 Payment by Electronic Funds Transfer— System for Award Management (Oct 2018)
- ☒ 52.237-2 Protection of Government Buildings, Equipment, and Vegetation (Apr 1984)

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Other Applicable Clauses

52.245-1 Government Property (Sep 2021)
52.245-2 Government Property
52.247-34 F.O.B. Destination (Jan 1991)

AGAR Clauses

452.203-71 Anti-Discrimination and Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI) Compliance (Dec 2025)

(a) By entering into this contract, the Contractor certifies that:

- (1) It is compliant with all applicable Federal anti-discrimination laws and the Equal Protection principles of the U.S. Constitution, and it will remain compliant for the duration of the contract.
- (2) Neither it nor any subcontractor or teaming partner operates or funds any program, policy, or initiative that promotes DEI in a manner that violates any applicable Federal anti-discrimination laws, including but not limited to Title VI and VII of the Civil Rights Act of 1964, or the Equal Protection principles of the U.S. Constitution, and the Contractor and any subcontractor or teaming partner will not do so for the duration of the contract.

(b) If the Contractor participates in, facilitates, or funds programs that implicate Title VI of the Civil Rights Act of 1964 or Title IX of the Education Amendments of 1972, as amended, including but not limited to grants to or for schools, colleges, universities, 4-H programs, non-governmental organization (NGO) programs, sports programs, and education-related grants to prisons or other detention facilities, the Contractor certifies that it will remain compliant with those laws, including the requirements set forth in Executive Order 14168, Defending Women from Gender Ideology Extremism and Restoring Biological Truth to the Federal Government, and Executive Order 14173, Ending Illegal Discrimination and Restoring Merit-Based Opportunity.

(c) The Contractor affirms that the above requirements are conditions of payment that go to the essence of the contract and are therefore material terms of the contract. Payments under the contract are predicated on compliance with the above requirements, and therefore the Contractor is not eligible for funding under the contract or to retain any funding under the contract absent compliance with the above requirements.

(d) This certification reflects a change in the Government's position regarding the materiality of the foregoing requirements and therefore any prior payment of similar claims does not reflect the materiality of the foregoing requirements to this contract.

(e) Submission of a knowing false statement relating to Contractor's compliance with the above requirements and/or eligibility for the contract may subject the Contractor to liability under the False Claims Act, 31 U.S.C. § 3729, and/or criminal liability, including under 18 U.S.C. §§ 287 and 1001.

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(f) The Contractor must include the provisions of this clause in all subcontract solicitations.

(g) Failure on the part of the Contractor or its subcontractors to comply with the terms of this clause may be grounds for the Contracting Officer to terminate this contract for default.

(End of Clause)

AGAR 452.203-72 Unenforceable Supplier Terms

(a) Definitions.

Supplier terms mean provisions customarily drafted by vendors of supplies or services and intended to create a binding legal obligation on the end user. The term applies:

- (1) Regardless of the format or style of the document. For example, supplier terms may appear in standard terms of sale or lease, Terms of Service (TOS), End User License Agreement (EULA), or another similar legal instrument or agreement, and may be presented as part of a proposal or quotation responding to a solicitation for a contract or order or otherwise become effective after the contract date.
- (2) Regardless of the media or delivery mechanism used. For example, supplier terms may be presented as one or more paper documents or may appear on a computer or other electronic device screen during a purchase, software installation, other product delivery, registration for a service, or another transaction.

(b) Applicability. When any supply or service acquired under this contract is subject to supplier terms, the supplier terms are deemed part of the contract only to the extent they are consistent with this clause. Supplier terms that conflict with any part of this clause, the contract, or Federal law are void and will not be considered incorporated into a contract, even if they are physically present in a contract documentation or systems. In the event of any inconsistency between supplier terms and this contract, this clause and the terms of the Government contract shall govern and supersede any supplier terms in all cases.

(c) Authorization Required. Notwithstanding any other provision, no supplier terms shall be binding on the Government unless the term is expressly authorized on the USDA Supplier Terms Authorization Form signed by the Contracting Officer, and the completed Authorization Form has been incorporated into the contract.

(d) Unenforceable Terms. Any supplier terms that impose obligations or restrictions inconsistent with applicable Federal law are unenforceable against the Government and deemed stricken from the agreement. This includes, but is not limited to, any clause that:

- (1) Requires the Government to pay future fees, penalties, interest, legal costs, early-termination fees, cancellation fees, minimum purchase commitments, true-up payments, seat-count minimums, usage minimums, continued-use charges, or any other financial obligation not expressly authorized by the contract.

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- (2) Requires the Government to indemnify the contractor or any other entity.
- (3) Restricts the Government's ability to obtain similar supplies or services from another source.
- (4) Imposes any penalty, financial or otherwise, based on the Government's decision not to exercise an option.
- (5) Subjects the United States Government to the laws of any U.S. state, territory, district, municipality, or foreign nation, except where Federal law expressly permits such application.
- (6) Requires dispute resolution in a forum or venue other than one prescribed by applicable Federal law.
- (7) Establishes a period of limitations for bringing an action that differs from that provided by applicable Federal law.
- (8) Grants the contractor rights to use, mine, access, aggregate, analyze, or otherwise exploit Government data, usage data, or metadata.
- (9) Deems the Government to have accepted initial or revised terms based on silence, continued performance, or failure to object.
- (10) Grants the supplier the right to audit Government facilities, systems, records, or use of the product or service, except as expressly authorized by the contract and applicable Federal law.
- (11) Requires the Government to accept supplier security requirements, network access requirements, monitoring, penetration testing, or other technical or security measures.
- (12) Permits the supplier to suspend, degrade, or terminate access to products or services based on alleged non-payment, alleged breach, automated security triggers.
- (13) Limits the Government's right to use, install, access, test, evaluate, or transfer the licensed product or service in any manner consistent with the contract and Federal law.
- (14) Requires the Government to store, process, maintain, or transmit data in a particular geographic location, or permits the supplier to transfer Government data outside the United States, except as expressly authorized by applicable Federal law.
- (15) Authorizes the supplier to use the Government's name, seal, trademark, logo, or any reference to the Government as an end user or customer for marketing, publicity, promotional activities, press releases, or similar purposes.
- (16) Incorporates by reference, or requires the Government to accept, terms or conditions imposed by any third party, subcontractor, or upstream service provider, unless such terms are expressly incorporated into the contract by bilateral modification.

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- (17) Limits, conditions, or negates the contractor's performance obligations, service levels, or remedies through a supplier-provided service level agreement (SLA).
 - (18) Uses Government data, usage data, metadata, prompts, content, or interactions to train, fine-tune, improve, or derive any artificial intelligence, machine learning, or automated decision-making model.
 - (19) Subjects the Government to automated decision-making, automated risk scoring, automated content moderation, or any algorithmic process that may affect access, performance, or rights under the contract.
 - (20) Utilizes artificial intelligence or algorithmic tools that produce decisions, recommendations, or outputs affecting contract performance without providing transparency, explainability, auditability, and bias-mitigation consistent with applicable Federal law and policy.
 - (21) Profiles, tracks, or analyzes Government user behavior, preferences, communications, or interactions for personalization, marketing, or algorithmic optimization purposes.
- (e) Non-binding Actions. Neither the Government nor any Government authorized end user is deemed to have consented to any term, condition, or clause by virtue of its inclusion in the supplier agreement or through the use of clickwrap, browsewrap, "I agree" mechanisms, or similar means. Execution of such mechanisms does not bind the Government or its authorized end users to any unenforceable terms.
- (f) End user. The supplier agreement shall bind the ordering activity as the end user to the extent it does not conflict with the terms of this clause, but it shall not bind or impose personal liability on any Government employee or any person acting on behalf of the Government in their personal capacity.
- (g) Law and disputes. The supplier agreement is governed by Federal law.
- (h) Statutory exception. This clause does not apply to indemnification or any other payment by the Government that is expressly authorized by statute and specifically authorized under applicable agency regulations and procedures.
- (i) Continued performance. The supplier or licensor shall not unilaterally revoke, terminate, or suspend any rights granted to the Government except as allowed by the contract. If the supplier or licensor believes the ordering activity to be in breach of the supplier agreement, it shall pursue its rights under the Contract Disputes Act or other applicable Federal statute while proceeding diligently with performance, pending final resolution of any dispute in accordance with the Disputes Clause at FAR 52.212-4(d) or FAR 52.233-1, as applicable.
- (j) Arbitration. Binding arbitration shall not be used unless specifically authorized by agency guidance.

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(k) Equitable or injunctive relief. Equitable or injunctive relief, including the award of attorney fees, costs, or interest, may be awarded against the United States Government only when explicitly provided by statute (e.g., the Prompt Payment Act or the Equal Access to Justice Act).

(l) Revisions to supplier agreements. Any revisions to the supplier agreement must be incorporated into the contract using a bilateral modification. Unilateral revisions are not binding on the Government.

(m) No automatic renewals. If any license or service tied to periodic payment is provided under the supplier agreement (e.g., annual software maintenance or annual lease term), such license or service shall not renew automatically upon expiration of its current term without prior express written consent from an authorized Government representative.

(n) Indemnification. Any clause of the supplier agreement requiring the supplier or licensor to defend or indemnify the end user is amended to provide that the U.S. Department of Justice has the sole right to represent the United States in any such action, in accordance with 28 U.S.C. 516.

(o) Taxes or surcharges. Any taxes or surcharges which the supplier or licensor seeks to pass along to the Government as end user will be governed by the terms of the associated Government contract or order and must be submitted to the Contracting Officer for a determination of applicability prior to invoicing unless specifically agreed otherwise.

(p) Non-assignment. The supplier agreement may not be assigned, nor may any rights or obligations thereunder be delegated, without the Government's prior approval, except as expressly permitted by FAR 52.212-4(b) or FAR 52.232-23, as applicable.

(q) Confidential information. If the supplier agreement includes a confidentiality clause, such clause is amended to state that neither the agreement nor the contract price list, as applicable, shall be deemed "confidential information." Issues regarding release of "unit pricing" will be resolved consistent with the Freedom of Information Act. Notwithstanding anything in the supplier agreement to the contrary, the Government may retain any confidential information as required by law, regulation, or its internal document retention procedures for legal, regulatory, or compliance purposes; provided, however, that all such retained confidential information will continue to be subject to the confidentiality obligations of the supplier agreement.

(r) Conflict with Federal law. If any other language, provision, or clause of the supplier agreement conflicts or is inconsistent with Federal law or the terms and conditions of this contract, such language, provisions, or clauses will be considered null and void and will not be binding on the United States Government.

(End of Clause)

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452.204-70 Modification for Contract Closeout (Apr 2026)

(a) If unliquidated funds in the amount of \$1000 or less remain on the contract, the Contracting Officer (Contracting Officer) may issue a unilateral modification for deobligation. The contractor will receive a copy of the modification but is not required to provide a signature. The Contracting Officer will immediately proceed with contract closeout upon completion of the period of performance, receipt and acceptance of supplies or services, and final payment.

(b) For commercial contracts not exceeding the simplified acquisition procedure threshold under FAR 12.001(c), if more than \$1,000 in unliquidated funds remain at closeout, the Contracting Officer will issue a bilateral deobligation modification. Only the modification requires the contractor's signature, though a Release of Claims may be requested. If the required documents are not returned within 60 days, the Contracting Officer will issue a unilateral modification and proceed with closeout once performance is complete, acceptance is confirmed, and final payment is made.

(c) For all other non-commercial or non-cost-reimbursement contracts, if more than \$1,000 in unliquidated funds remain at closeout, the Contracting Officer will issue a bilateral deobligation modification and a Release of Claims, both requiring contractor signature. If these documents are not returned within 120 days, the Contracting Officer will issue a unilateral modification and proceed with closeout upon completion of performance, acceptance, and final payment.

(End of Clause)

452.204-72 Use of Electronic Data Interchange (EDI) or Other Automation Technologies (Apr 2026)

(a) In the event that Electronic Data Interchange (EDI) functionality or other automation technologies such as Robotics Process Automation is utilized to facilitate electronic transactions between USDA and its contractors, it is the sole responsibility of the Contractor to ensure accuracy of the electronically transferred data. The Government's electronic system shall serve as the system of record for all data exchanged or retrieved.

(b) The Government shall not be liable to the Contractor for any delay or failure associated with EDI or other automation technologies. The Contractor's use of this service is at the Contractor's sole risk. For electronic or automated services provided by USDA to the contractor, the services are provided on an "as is" and "as available" basis. For electronic or automated services provided by the contractor that interact with the USDA electronic systems, the USDA is not responsible for any costs incurred by the contractor related to the development, test, or support of the services. The Contractor shall be responsible for all fees associated with EDI. The Contractor is responsible for the confidentiality and security of its systems, interfaces, interconnections, and any documents that the customer receives from The Government pursuant to the contract.

(c) The Government reserves the right to restrict, refuse, or cancel any participation in EDI services.

(End of clause)

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Solicitation Information

Award Type

It is anticipated that a firm-fixed price requirements contract consisting of one (1) one-year base period and no options periods shall be awarded as a result of this synopsis/solicitation. The total duration of this contract shall not exceed one (1) year.

The Government intends to make one award from this solicitation. Therefore, to be considered responsive, contractors must submit pricing for all items.

Evaluation and Basis for Award

The provision at FAR 52.212-2, Evaluation—Commercial Products and Commercial Services is not applicable to this solicitation. In lieu of this provision, quotes will be evaluated in accordance with FAR 12.203 based on the criteria listed below. Award will be made to the offeror representing the best value to the Government.

Technical Approach:

The technical approach will evaluate the ability of the offeror to provide a sound and compliant approach that meets all requirements and shows a thorough understanding of them. It is the contractor's responsibility to ensure their quotation clearly demonstrates their capability to meet these requirements. All offerors must provide the following minimum information and documentation with their quotations to be considered responsive and have their offers evaluated:

Contractor must send a technical capability statement briefly explaining:

- (a) Qualifications and experience of the crew(s) and any proposed subcontractors.
 - (1) Experience with and knowledge of the flora of the upper Midwest, especially the western Upper Peninsula of Michigan and the genus *Botrychium*.
 - (2) Experience in conducting botany field surveys in the upper Midwest.
 - (3) Experience in successfully and safely locating new rare plant populations.
- (b) Capacity to accomplish the project in the required time in accordance with the Statement of Work. The contractor must provide a detailed explanation of any requirement listed in the SOW that cannot be successfully accomplished by the offeror. Contractor must also identify key personnel and resources to be dedicated to this project. This information should include key personnel qualifications, which include individuals' name, individual experience, present position, work history, education and certifications.

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Price:

The offeror shall provide pricing as requested in the Schedule of Items on page 1 of this Request for Quote. Failure to propose pricing for all individual line items may result in a quotation being excluded from further consideration. The offeror's quotation will be evaluated in accordance with FAR 12.204, to determine if it is fair and reasonable.

Past Performance:

The Government may utilize any references provided by the Contractor, along with information available from past contracts/orders with the USDA and any information found using sources such as Federal Government sources or the Contractor Performance Assessment Reporting System (CPARS) to determine if the Contractor has acceptable or neutral Past Performance. Past Performance will be evaluated using the following rating system:

- Acceptable: The contractor shows a demonstrated ability to meet contract requirements in prior or current contracts, including quality of work, timeliness, cost control, business relations, and adherence to contract terms.
- Neutral: Offeror does not have a past performance record.
- Unacceptable: The contractor has a documented history of failing to meet contract requirements, including poor quality, missed deadlines, cost overruns, lack of responsiveness, or unethical behavior.

Evaluation Method

The Government will evaluate quotations based on the lowest price technically acceptable criteria. Only the lowest priced offer will be evaluated for Technical Acceptability. Should the lowest priced offer not receive an acceptable technical or past performance rating, the process will continue in order of lowest priced offer until the lowest price, technically acceptable offer with acceptable or neutral past performance is identified.

Delivery Information

F.o.b. destination, is requested as the F.O.B. point for all deliverables.

All offers will be considered F.O.B. Destination unless F.O.B. origin is specified AND estimated shipping costs are included.

The USDA requires delivery of all items by 09/15/2026. Early deliveries will be accepted.

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52.252-1 Solicitation Provisions Incorporated by Reference Feb 1998

This solicitation incorporates one or more solicitation provisions by reference, with the same force and effect as if they were given in full text. Upon request, the Contracting Officer will make their full text available. The offeror is cautioned that the listed provisions may include blocks that must be completed by the offeror and submitted with its quotation or offer. In lieu of submitting the full text of those provisions, the offeror may identify the provision by paragraph identifier and provide the appropriate information with its quotation or offer. Also, the full text of a solicitation provision may be accessed electronically at this/these address(es): <https://www.acquisition.gov/far-overhaul/far-part-deviation-guide/far-overhaul-part-52>

52.212-1 Instructions to Offerors - Commercial Products and Commercial Services (Nov 2025)

FAR 52.212-1 is amended as follows:

Offerors must have an active entity registration in the System for Award Management in order to submit an offer. <https://www.sam.gov/SAM/>

Quotes shall be submitted via email to christopher.j.hamilton@usda.gov and are due no later than May 22, 2026, at 1200 PM, Central Time. Emails should contain the following attachments: Attachment A, Schedule of Items, and Attachment H, Experience Questionnaire.

Questions

Questions shall be submitted via email to christopher.j.hamilton@usda.gov and are due no later than May 14, 2026, at 1200 PM Central Time. This will ensure enough time to respond before the solicitation period ends. Please include the solicitation name and number as the subject line of the email.

- 52.203-18 Prohibition on Contracting with Entities that Require Certain Internal Confidentiality Agreements or Statements-Representation (Jan 2017)
- 52.209-2 Prohibition on Contracting with Inverted Domestic Corporations - Representation (Sep 2025)
- 52.209-11 Representation by Corporations Regarding Delinquent Tax Liability or a Felony Conviction under any Federal Law (Sep 2025)
- 52.240-90 Security Prohibitions and Exclusions Representations and Certifications (Nov 2025)

The following provisions are applicable if checked:

- ☒ 52.204-7 System for Award Management—Registration (Nov 2025)

Other Applicable FAR Provisions

- 52.237-1 Site Visits (Apr 1984)

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AGAR Provisions

452.203-70 Anti-Discrimination and Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI) Certification (Dec 2025)

(a) By submission of its offer, the offeror certifies that:

- (3) It is compliant with all applicable Federal anti-discrimination laws and the Equal Protection principles of the U.S. Constitution.
- (4) Neither it nor any proposed subcontractor or teaming partner operates or funds any program, policy, or initiative that promotes DEI in a manner that violates any applicable Federal anti-discrimination laws, including but not limited to Title VI and VII of the Civil Rights Act of 1964, or the Equal Protection principles of the U.S. Constitution.

(b) If the offeror participates in, facilitates, or funds programs that implicate Title VI of the Civil Rights Act of 1964 or Title IX of the Education Amendments of 1972, as amended, including but not limited to grants to or for schools, colleges, universities, 4-H programs, non-governmental organization (NGO) programs, sports programs, and education-related grants to prisons or other detention facilities, by submission of its offer, the offeror certifies that it is compliant with those laws, including the requirements set forth in Executive Order 14168, Defending Women from Gender Ideology Extremism and Restoring Biological Truth to the Federal Government, and Executive Order 14173, Ending Illegal Discrimination and Restoring Merit-Based Opportunity.

(c) The offeror affirms that the above requirements are conditions of payment that go to the essence of the contract and are therefore material terms of the contract. Payments under the contract are predicated on compliance with the above requirements, and therefore the offeror will not be eligible for funding under the contract or to retain any funding under the contract absent compliance with the above requirements.

(d) This certification reflects a change in the Government's position regarding the materiality of the foregoing requirements and therefore any prior payment of similar claims does not reflect the materiality of the foregoing requirements to this contract.

(e) Submission of a knowing false statement relating to offeror's compliance with the above requirements and/or eligibility for the contract may subject the offeror to liability under the False Claims Act, 31 U.S.C. § 3729, and/or criminal liability, including under 18 U.S.C. §§ 287 and 1001.

(f) Failure on the part of the offeror or its subcontractors to comply with the terms of this clause may be grounds for the Contracting Officer to terminate the contract for default.

(End of Provision)

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NOTICE FOR FILING AGENCY PROTESTS
United States Department of Agriculture (USDA) Ombudsman Program

The USDA is committed to issuing solicitations and awarding contracts in a fair and prompt manner. The Ombudsman Program for Agency Protests (OPAP) was established to address protest issues within the agency, providing an alternative to costly and time-consuming litigation. Operating independently, OPAP offers relief comparable to that granted by the Government Accountability Office (GAO). Interested parties are encouraged to resolve concerns through USDA's internal Alternative Dispute Resolution (ADR) process before pursuing external forums such as the GAO. Concerns may be addressed informally or through a formal agency protest filed with either the Contracting Officer or the Ombudsman.

Informal Forum with the Ombudsman

1. **Initial Point of Contact:** Interested parties who believe a specific USDA procurement is unfair or otherwise defective should first direct their concerns to the applicable Contracting Officer.
2. **Escalation:** If the Contracting Officer is unable to address their concerns, interested parties are encouraged to contact the USDA Ombudsman for Agency Protests. Under this informal process, the agency is not required to suspend contract award performance. Utilization of the informal forum does not suspend any time requirement for filing a formal protest with the agency or other forums.
3. **Required Information:** To ensure a timely response, interested parties should provide the following information to the Ombudsman: solicitation/contract number, contracting office, Contracting Officer, and solicitation closing date (if applicable).

Formal Agency Protest with the Ombudsman

1. **Effort to Resolve:** Prior to submitting a formal agency protest, protesters must first use their best efforts to resolve their concerns with the Contracting Officer through open and frank discussions.
2. **Independent Review:** If the protester's concerns remain unresolved, an Independent Review is available by the Ombudsman. The protester may file a formal agency protest with either the Contracting Officer or, alternatively, with the Ombudsman under the OPAP program. Contract awards or performance will be suspended during the protest period unless justified in writing for urgent and compelling reasons or determined in writing to be in the best interest of the Government.
3. **Resolution Timeline:** The agency's goal is to resolve protests within 35 calendar days from the date of filing.
4. **Required Information:** Protests shall include the information set forth in FAR 33.104(a)(3). Failure to submit the required information may result in a delay or dismissal of the protest.
5. **Timeliness:** Protests must be filed within the timeframes specified in FAR 33.104.
6. **Submission:** Formal protests under the OPAP program should be submitted electronically to SPE.inquiry@usda.gov and the Contracting Officer.

Election of Forum. By initiating a protest with the USDA, the protester agrees not to pursue the same matter with the Government Accountability Office (GAO) or any other external forum while the agency protest is pending. If a protest is filed externally, the agency protest will be dismissed.